alert to their borders, where they started skirmishing in November, eventually going to war in December.[134]

This crisis was the dominant issue in US-India relations in 1971. Nixon and Kissinger saw their evolving rapprochement with China threatened by Indian actions during the crisis. Their response set off a chain reaction that culminated in US-India relations hitting a low point. India, in turn, found that it could no longer count on US assistance against China. This led Delhi to tilt toward Moscow.

In a background briefing to Congress in the midst of the crisis, Kissinger refuted the notion that "US policy is motivated primarily by (a) considerations of China policy, or (b) a gut-loathing for the Indians."[135] The Nixon administration's evolving triangular diplomacy, including the China rapprochement, however, was indeed a major determinant of the US approach, with personal inclinations playing a role as well. Nixon and Kissinger saw this crisis through a global prism. Gandhi, on the other hand, saw the situation as a regional one that became a little too local for comfort as millions of refugees streamed across India's borders from East Pakistan. Her government initially saw the situation developing on India's eastern flank as a threat but later also as an opportunity.

Early Reactions

Gandhi, newly empowered at home thanks to a significant election victory in March, had initially been reluctant to support East Pakistani calls for independence. While there was popular sympathy in India for the Bengalis in East Pakistan and even support in the circle close to Gandhi for the guerrillas, the prime minister tried to dampen calls for greater Indian involvement.[136] The military leadership had informed her that any successful intervention would not be feasible at that time. The troops deployed in eastern India were primarily equipped for election duty, and the imminent monsoon season would make operations harder.[137] In addition, there was precedent to think about; a Tamil leader was demanding greater autonomy for Indian states and suggesting parallels with the situation in East Pakistan.[138] Furthermore, while Delhi did nothing to stop East Bengali guerrillas operating from its territory, it expected Pakistani military authorities to take back control relatively quickly and then return to the negotiating table with the AL.[139]